

B. Allocation Package Narrative Explanation

Lassen County, California is located on the eastern slope of the Sierra Nevada mountains in northeastern California approximately 90 miles northwest of Reno, Nevada, and approximately 200 miles northeast of Sacramento, California. Lassen County is bound by Modoc County to the north, Shasta County to the west, Plumas and Sierra Counties to the south, and Washoe County (State of Nevada) to the east. The County contains one incorporated city (Susanville) and one federally recognized tribal entity (Susanville Indian Rancheria). The U.S. Census reported the population of Lassen County at 32,730 in 2020, including an inmate and institutionalized population of about 8,750. In 2020, Susanville had a population of about 16,730, half of the county's total population, including an institutionalized population of approximately 7,600.

The median household income in Lassen County was estimated at \$56,971 in 2020, which is 73 percent of the statewide average. This classifies some census tracts as disadvantaged communities by income. Lassen County has offered public transportation services since 1981. Lassen County has one public transit operator: the Lassen Transit Services Agency (LTSA), which provides local fixed route service in Susanville, inter-community routes, and Dial-A-Ride services for individuals who qualify. These services provide mobility to the county's residents, including access to important medical, recreational, social, and economic services and opportunities. Public transit is an integral element to ensuring quality of life for Lassen County residents.

i. An explanation of what funding and service actions are being taken within the region that utilize resources other than SB125 funding.

Assuming the Fiscal Year (FY) 2021-22 service baseline (Vehicle Service Hours: 10,691; Vehicle Service Miles: 216,138), it is anticipated that the LTSA will be faced with an annual operating deficit from FY 2024-25 onward. This can be attributed to a combination of factors: the gradual decrease in Local Transportation Fund (LTF) allocations due to a forecasted population decrease in Lassen County, the projected gradual increase in annual operating costs, and the termination of Coronavirus Response and Relief Supplemental Appropriations Act (CRRSAA) funds beyond FY 2023-24. LTSA has judiciously used all available funding up to this point and an operating surplus of \$6,543 is expected for FY 2023-24, enabling LTSA to continue to provide a baseline level of service. An operational deficit of \$298,072 and \$351,355 is projected for FY 2024-25 and FY 2025-26, respectively, however. These figures, along with projected revenues and expenditures, can be found in the *LTSA Revenue and Expenditures* worksheet in the Excel file included. As Lassen County Transportation Commission (LCTC) already allocates all LTF and State Transit Assistance (STA) funds to operating, the option to simply postpone low priority capital projects in favor of meeting the projected operating deficit is not an option. Even though the LTSA will continue to claim and allocate all available formula and discretionary funds, LTSA will be forced to cut service (e.g., hours of service, days per week of service, or length of routes) to reduce operating costs. If no additional funds are found, LTSA will be required to reduce service by 52 percent from the 2022 baseline by FY 2024-25. This level of reduction equates to the elimination of the West County Route and reduced service frequency on the Susanville City Route. Reduction in service frequency on a local fixed route

may lead to significant decreases in ridership. Service reduction would be detrimental to the communities served that rely on transit services for work and day to day activities.

LTSA will have a capital fund balance of \$267,391 and total capital revenue of \$317,355 for FY 2023-24. This provides LTSA with the opportunity to make much-needed capital improvements in FY 2023-24, such as vehicle replacement and improvements to the LTSA maintenance facility. With no more CRSSAA funds available, it is expected that annual capital revenue in FY 2024-25 and FY 2025-26 will be funded by State of Good Repair and will total an estimated \$52,103 and \$53,666, respectively. In FY 2024-25, this amounts to 8.6 percent of what is required to meet the scheduled vehicle replacement costs, as determined by the LTSA vehicle replacement schedule. In FY 2025-26, this amounts to 4.7 percent of scheduled vehicle replacement costs. Without additional funding allocated by SB 125, LTSA will not be able to replace any buses. As vehicle replacement is required per the ICT ZEB Rollout Plan, a dearth of funding will result in LTSA not being in compliance with the requirements of ICT for both these fiscal years.

ii. A description and justification of the RTPA strategy to use SB 125 funding to construct capital projects and fund operating expenses that lead to improved outcomes in its jurisdiction.

SB 125 funds will be used directly by the LTSA to address the expected operational deficit in FY 2024-25 through FY 2026-27. SB 125 funds applied to operating expenses will mitigate service cuts that would otherwise have to be made to keep the LTSA a solvent transit system. By allocating \$1,000,000 of SB 125 funds to the operating deficit, LTSA can continue to provide 2022 baseline service through FY 25-26 and with minimal service reduction in FY 26-27. Without SB 125 funds LTSA will be forced to consider fare increases, reduction in service hours and miles, and even personnel layoffs, all of which would severely harm transit dependent riders and the wider community. If LTSA is forced to drastically reduce transit service, the system will lose reliability and dependability, as riders will not feel comfortable taking a job or making other day to day decisions if they are unsure about the ability to get there. Maintaining consistent and reliable public transit service is important for keeping and growing the ridership base.

In addition to meeting the short-term operating deficit, LTSA plans to allocate a significant portion of the SB 125 funds to vehicle replacement and the implementation of associated Zero Emission Bus (ZEB) charging infrastructure, as scheduled in the Innovative Clean Transit (ICT) ZEB Rollout Plan: Zero-Emission Bus Analysis, Infrastructure Analysis and Rollout Plan for Lassen Transit Service Agency and Plumas Transit Systems. Adhering to the capital improvement schedule of the ZEB Rollout Plan is not only required under the California Air Resource Board (CARB), it also ensures that the LTSA revenue fleet remains in good, safe, and clean condition for riders. The transition to ZEBs will provide passengers with a much cleaner and quieter transit experience. This transition provides LTSA with a unique opportunity to market ZEBs, encourage a wide array of community members to ride the new buses, and market public transit services in Lassen County. Not only will the capital investments enabled by SB 125 maintain the safety and cleanliness of the active bus fleet, but they may also increase ridership.

A total of \$200,000 of SB 125 funds will be used to implement a pilot program that will increase overall ridership and better meet the needs of the region. A Non-Emergency Medical Transportation (NEMT) service to Reno from Lassen County will be funded with SB 125. As Lassen County is a very rural county with minimal medical services, many residents must travel to Reno for specialty medical appointments. Many of these residents do not have transportation of their own yet are not eligible for transportation through Medi-cal. Medicare does not pay for transportation to medical appointments. Offering demand response transit service to Reno one day per week will meet an unmet transit need that has been brought up regularly through Social Service Transportation Advisory Council meetings, as well as increase overall ridership of the LTSA system.

iii. A detailed breakdown and justification for how the funding is proposed to be distributed between transit operators and among projects, consistent with the legislative intent described in SB 125.

All funding available to Lassen County under SB 125 will be allocated to the LTSA as the sole public transit operator in the County.

A total of \$1,000,000 will be allocated to transit operations in order to address a deficit in operating costs until long-term financial sustainability solutions are identified and implemented. This allocation will enable the LTSA to prevent service cuts and maintain 2022 baseline service levels. Preventing cuts to service will ensure that transit services are available for transit dependent populations and that LTSA continues to provide transit services representative of the needs of a significant percentage of the region's ridership.

The capital projects identified for funding are high priority, as they are improvements required by state mandate. The implementation of pilot programs such as essential non-emergency medical transportation service are justified through multiple requests for this type of service during the Unmet Transit Needs (UTN) process. The transition of the LTSA active fleet to ZEBs is significant to the region and to the state, supporting statewide emission reduction goals. LCTC and LTSA do not have any existing TIRCP-funded capital projects that are in need of additional funds.

C. Allocation Package Detailed Project Description

The LCTC will distribute a total of \$3,965,630 TIRCP and ZETCP funds in FY 2023-24 through FY 2026-27 to LTSA, the sole public transit operator in Lassen County. These funds will be for operating (\$1,000,000 in TIRCP funds) and for capital projects (\$2,965,630 in TIRCP and ZETCP funds). A total of \$100,000 will be utilized by the LCTC to conduct a countywide Zero-Emission Vehicle (ZEV) study. A total of \$41,067 (1 percent of total LCTC funding distribution) will be reserved for RTPA administrative costs and will be drawn from both TIRCP and ZETCP funds. The individual project costs are as follows:

- LTSA Operating Deficit (Operating) -\$1,000,000
- NEMT Service to Reno (Capital)-\$200,000
- Vehicle Replacement (ZEV Plan) (Capital)-\$1,843,737
- Charging Infrastructure (Capital)-\$921,893
- Countywide ZEV Study (Capital)-\$100,000
- RTPA Administrative Costs (Admin)-\$41,067

Individual Project Fact Sheets

Transit Operations Funding – LTSA Operating Deficit

1. Name of Transit Operator: Lassen Transit Services Agency (LTSA)
2. 2022-2023 ridership: 71,184. Percent of region's total ridership: 100%.
3. Funding Requested: \$334,937 (TIRCP, FY23-24); \$665,063 (TIRCP, FY24-25).
4. Specific Activities Funded: This TIRCP allocation will enable LTSA to maintain 2022 levels of service and will fund approximately 19,362 revenue service hours over a 4 year period. This allocation will directly prevent significant reduction in service (e.g., frequency, coverage, or hours of service) that would be required should the LTSA not receive additional funding. Operating costs also cover routine vehicle maintenance, safety checks and cleaning, all vital components of a safe and reliable transit system. As LTSA is the sole public transit operator in Lassen County, they are wholly responsible for providing general public transportation for residents. By allocating funds to operating (to directly address the expected operating deficit), financial investment is being made in maintaining current ridership and encouraging increased ridership. Continuing to provide a reliable, safe, and clean public transit system with consistent transit service is paramount to enticing new riders and maintaining a good impression of the LTSA in the wider community.
5. Maintaining the current level of service and providing a reliable transit system will directly benefit transit dependent riders in Lassen County. LTSA service enables transit dependent individuals to access medical and social services, commercial areas, and social opportunities within Lassen County and beyond. A reduction in frequency of service or span of service will directly impact the ability that transit dependent persons have at accessing these essential services and increase transportation inequity in the county. It is critical that the LTSA can maintain these relied-upon services for those who need it most.

TIRCP Capital- NEMT Service to Reno

a. Summary:

- i. Implementing Agencies: LCTC/LTSA.
 - ii. Project Title: Non-Medical Emergency Transportation (NEMT) to Reno
 - iii. Dates of Project Implementation: FY 2023-24: project planning; FY 2024-25: Service implementation, dependent on vehicle procurement and driver availability.
 - iv. Summary of Project Scope: NEMT service to Reno has been identified as an unmet transit need (UTN) by the community in Lassen County. As Lassen County is a very rural county, residents routinely are required to travel to Reno for essential medical appointments. Sage Stage (Modoc County provides intercity transportation between Susanville and Reno; however, there is insufficient layover time in Reno to attend a medical appointment. The implementation of NEMT service to Reno by LCTC and LTSA would help meet this need of residents. It should also be noted that Lassen Senior Services (who used to provide some transportation to Reno) has stopped providing service. Furthermore, it is expected that as the county population ages in place, the demand for out-of-county medical services will increase, thus increasing the demand for an NEMT service. Providing NEMT service to Reno was identified in the 2021 Lassen County Transit Development Plan (TDP). This NEMT service would consist of a single roundtrip from Susanville, CA to Reno, NV and back two days per week (a one-way distance of approximately 90 miles). The vehicle would have sufficient layover time in Reno for passengers to go to medical appointments and be able to provide pick-up/drop-offs at the medical facility. TIRCP funds would be utilized to purchase a new zero-emission van, implement the service, and pay for one year of operating costs for this pilot program.
 - v. Total Project Cost: \$200,000 (operating and capital including \$5,000 for project management)
 - vi. Identification of Funds: \$200,000 (TIRCP, FY 23-24).
- b. Project Schedule: Service implementation is planned to begin FY 2023-24 with the procurement process for the zero-emission van. The project has been identified as an UTN and is in the planning phase.
- c. Project Location: The proposed NEMT service would have designated stops in Susanville and drop off passengers directly at their medical appointment in Reno. Potential request stops in Janesville, Herlong, and Doyle would be available. Advance reservations would be required. Refer to Figure 1 for a map of the proposed route.
- i. A KML file is included as a separate component of the Allocation Package showing the proposed NEMT route and stops.
 - ii. Housing Density across all of Lassen County is very low relative to densities found throughout the state of California. According to the U.S. Census Bureau American Community Survey (ACS), all census tracts within Lassen County fall in the lowest 20 percent of housing densities by census tracts in California. Housing densities range from 1 housing unit per square mile in northern

Lassen County to 596 in downtown Susanville. This route would serve at least one stop in downtown Susanville as well as serve outlying communities along the route.

- iii. Refer to Figures 2-5 for LTSA routes and service area and activity centers.
- iv. Refer to Figures 6-7 for existing and planned active transportation infrastructure.
- d. Explanation of GHG reduction features: The implementation of a NEMT service to Reno is likely to reduce greenhouse gas emissions (GHGs) as individuals who are currently using private passenger cars to travel from Lassen County to Reno can utilize a shared public transit bus instead. The 2021 TDP suggests that requiring a minimum of two passengers per trip would help ensure a minimum level of efficiency. A passenger minimum would further increase the impact of this service on GHG reduction. Even more impactful to GHG reduction is the planned utilization of a small zero-emission van.
- e. Expected ridership benefits and service integration: Providing additional lifeline service to Reno has been identified as a need for the past several years of UTN hearings and was included as a plan element in the most recent update of the Lassen County TDP. The implementation of NEMT service to Reno will have a significant positive impact on ridership and on addressing the mobility needs of the community. This service will integrate with the existing LTSA services (e.g., the West County Route) by having stops at key transfer points in the county and having complimenting schedule times so passengers can make transfers. Furthermore, transfers from out-of-county destinations will be considered when service planning.
- f. Benefits to disadvantaged communities: This service would provide direct, meaningful, and assured benefit to zero-vehicle households who do not have access to a car, low-income households who are unable to afford the gas to drive to Reno, seniors who may not be able to or be comfortable driving to Reno, and disabled persons who are unable to drive. Lassen County has a median household income (MHI) that is only 73 percent of the statewide MHI, identifying the county as a whole as disadvantaged.

TIRCP Capital- Vehicle Replacement (ZEB Plan)

- a. Summary:
 - i. Implementing Agencies: LCTC/LTSA.
 - ii. Project Title: Vehicle Replacement (ZEB Plan)
 - iii. Dates of Project Implementation: According to the Fleet Phasing Plan 2023-2040 included in the LTSA SB125 Allocation Package Excel Spreadsheet.
 - iv. Summary of Project Scope: Aligning with the ICT Rollout Plan Fleet Phasing Plan, gradual replacement of LTSA vehicles will be undertaken. In total, this allocation will enable the purchase of three new revenue vehicles in FY 2024-25 and FY 2025-26.
 - v. Total Project Cost: \$1,843,737
 - vi. Identification of Funds: \$885,000 (TIRCP FY 23-24); \$958,737 (TIRCP FY 24-25).
- b. Project Schedule: Refer to the Fleet Phasing Plan 2023-2040 included in the LTSA SB125 Allocation Package Excel Spreadsheet.
- c. Project Location: LTSA maintenance facility yard in Susanville, CA. Buses will be used systemwide.
- d. Explanation of GHG reduction features: The transition of the LTSA active fleet to ZEBs in accordance with the LTSA ICT ZEB Rollout Plan will directly support statewide goals to reduce GHGs. This project will reduce GHGs significantly, improve air quality, and decrease bus noise throughout higher density community centers in Lassen County (such as downtown Susanville) and in residential neighborhoods on LTSA routes.
- e. Expected ridership benefits and service integration: As transit agencies throughout California (and elsewhere) transition from diesel to zero emission buses, it is important for LTSA to transition in a timely fashion to remain integrated into the wider region-wide public transit network. As shown in the LTSA SB 125 Allocation Package Excel Spreadsheet, LTSA does not currently have the funds to support vehicle replacement and the long-term transition to ZEBs. Having modern buses is highly beneficial to maintaining and increasing ridership as cleanliness and reliability are seen as significant positives to riders.
- f. Benefits to disadvantaged communities: Disadvantaged communities are disproportionately at risk of living in areas with poor air quality. The short-term replacement of revenue vehicles with new ones and the long-term transition of the LTSA bus fleet to ZEBs provides equity benefits to the residents of Lassen County, as over half of the census tracts in Lassen County qualify as disadvantaged by MHI income.

TIRCP and ZETCP Capital – ZEV Charging Infrastructure

- a. Summary:
 - i. Implementing Agencies: LCTC/LTSA.
 - ii. Project Title: ZEV Charging Infrastructure.
 - iii. Dates of Project Implementation: Gradual implementation will begin in FY 2025-26 as funding allows and infrastructure becomes available for purchase. Implementation will continue past the FY 2026-27 timeframe of the Allocation Package.
 - iv. Summary of Project Scope: As LTSA transitions its transit fleet to ZEBs, per the requirements of CARB and as scheduled in the ICT Rollout Plan, charging infrastructure is a vital complimentary capital improvement. It is also critically important that charging infrastructure is in place prior to the transition of the LTSA fleet, hence why prioritization of SB 125 funds has been given to ZEV charging infrastructure. LTSA will install ZEV charging infrastructure at its maintenance facility in Susanville, where buses will charge.
 - v. Total Project Cost: \$921,893
 - vi. Identification of Funds: \$600,000 (TIRCP FY 23-24 and 24-25); \$65,103 (ZETCP-PTA FY 23-24); \$256,790 (ZETCP-GGRF FY 24-25, FY 25-26, FY 26-27).
- b. Project Schedule: Project will begin as soon as funding can be secured.
- c. Project Location: LTSA storage and maintenance yard in Susanville, CA. This is the only LTSA storage facility for active fleet buses.
- d. Explanation of GHG reduction features: A successful transition to the use of ZEBs by the LTSA is completely dependent on the procurement and installation of ZEV charging infrastructure. Therefore, securing capital funds for ZEV charging infrastructure will lead to the reduction of GHGs, air quality improvement and reduction of bus noise in Lassen County and beyond.
- e. Expected ridership benefits and service integration: Similarly, the installation of ZEV charging infrastructure will indirectly benefit riders and may benefit ridership as the ZEB fleet will be modern, quiet, and reliable. Furthermore, the deployment of ZEV charging stations at the LTSA facility will integrate with the broader statewide efforts to reduce GHGs and transition public transit fleets to ZEBs.
- f. Benefits to disadvantaged communities: This project will support the transition of the LTSA vehicle fleet to ZEBs and provide air quality and equity benefits to disadvantaged communities.

ZETCP Capital – Countywide ZEV Study

- a. Summary:
 - i. Implementing Agencies: LCTC
 - ii. Project Title: Countywide ZEV Study.
 - iii. Dates of project implementation: LCTC will begin the Request for Proposal (RFP) process to retain a consultant to conduct a countywide ZEV Study as funding is secured in FY 2023-24.
 - iv. Summary of project: LCTC will retain a consultant firm to conduct a countywide ZEV study to thoughtfully prepare for and support the transition of passenger vehicles (beyond the public transit agency) to ZEVs. This study will evaluate opportunities and challenges to developing a complete ZEV charging network for both resident and visitor vehicles in Lassen County and recommend necessary steps for successful implementation. The study will include evaluation of the capacity of the utilities grid, potential sites for charging infrastructure based on land uses and travel patterns, and implementation cost.
 - v. Total Project Cost: \$100,000
 - vi. Funds: \$11,339.69 (ZETCP-PTA FY 23-24); \$88,660.31 (ZETCP-GGRF FY 23-24).
- b. Project Schedule: An RFP for a consultant will be published in FY 2023-24.
- c. Project Location: Countywide (Lassen County). Focus will be paid during the study on locating ZEV charging infrastructure within areas of high residential, commercial, and mixed-use density. Furthermore, the study will consider planned high density developments and activity centers as well as through travel.
- d. Explanation of GHG reduction features: Creating a complete and reliable network of ZEV charging facilities is vital to supporting statewide goals for GHG reduction.
- e. Expected ridership benefits and service integration: Deploying a well-planned network of ZEV charging facilities for public use will integrate with the broader ZEV charging network. The importance of developing a complete ZEV charging network in Lassen County cannot be understated as several major roadways pass through the County, including US 395 which has been designated as an Alternative Fuels Corridor.
- f. Benefits to disadvantaged communities: ZEV charging facilities throughout Lassen County (as planned for by this ZEV study) will encourage continued and increased tourism, a critical component to the economy of the County—where many disadvantaged communities rely on the economic benefits of tourism.

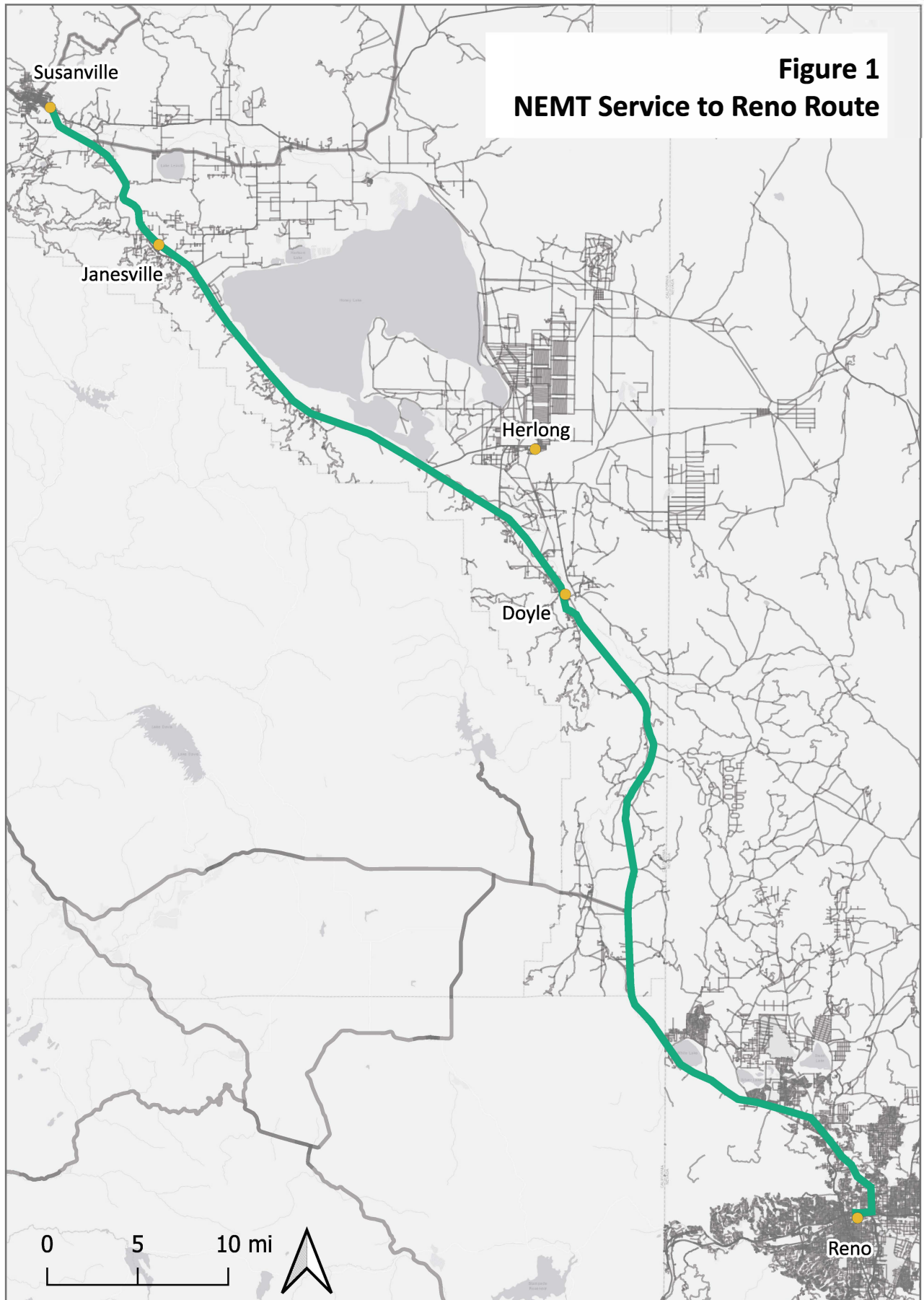


Figure 2
Lassen County Transit Routes

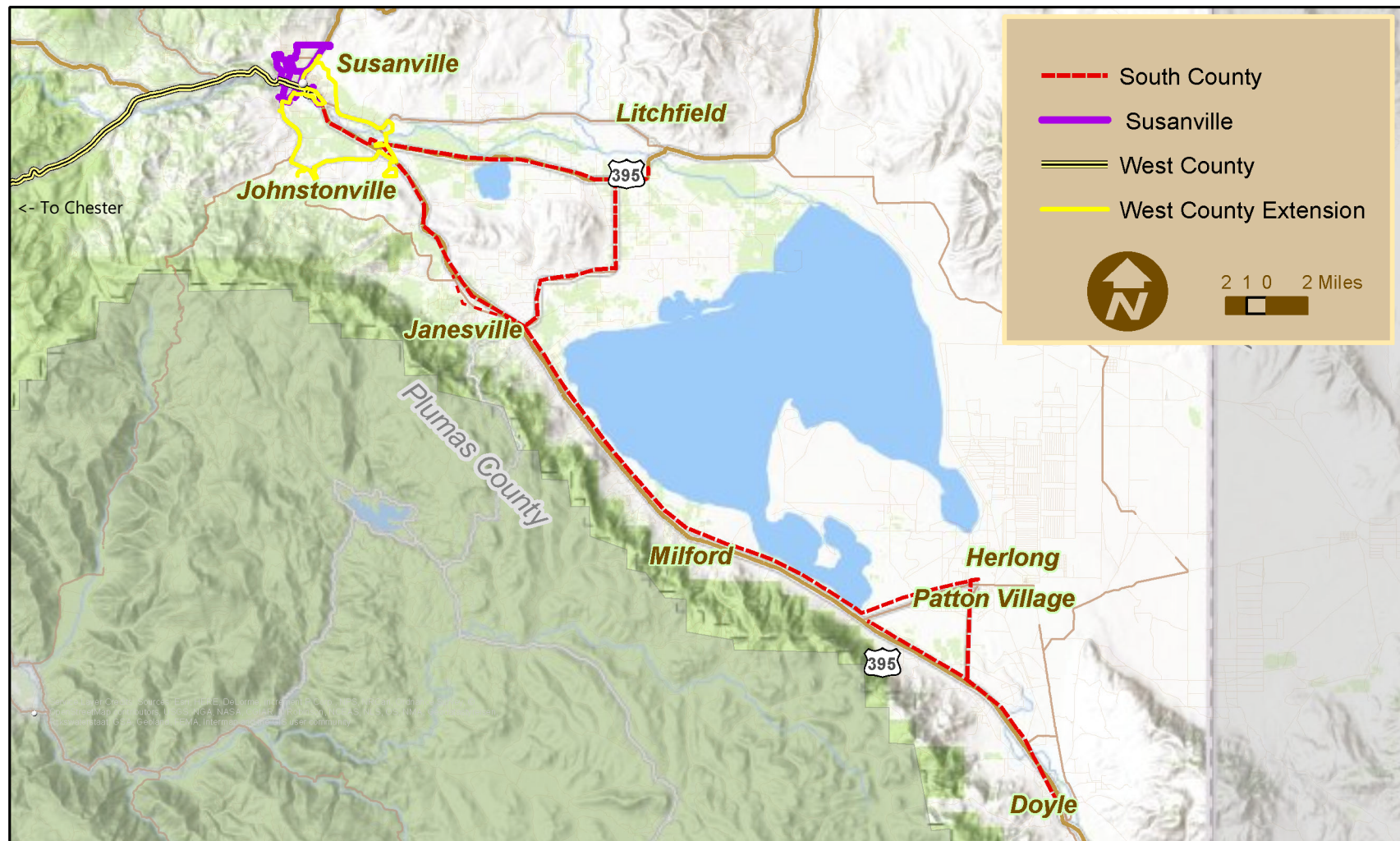
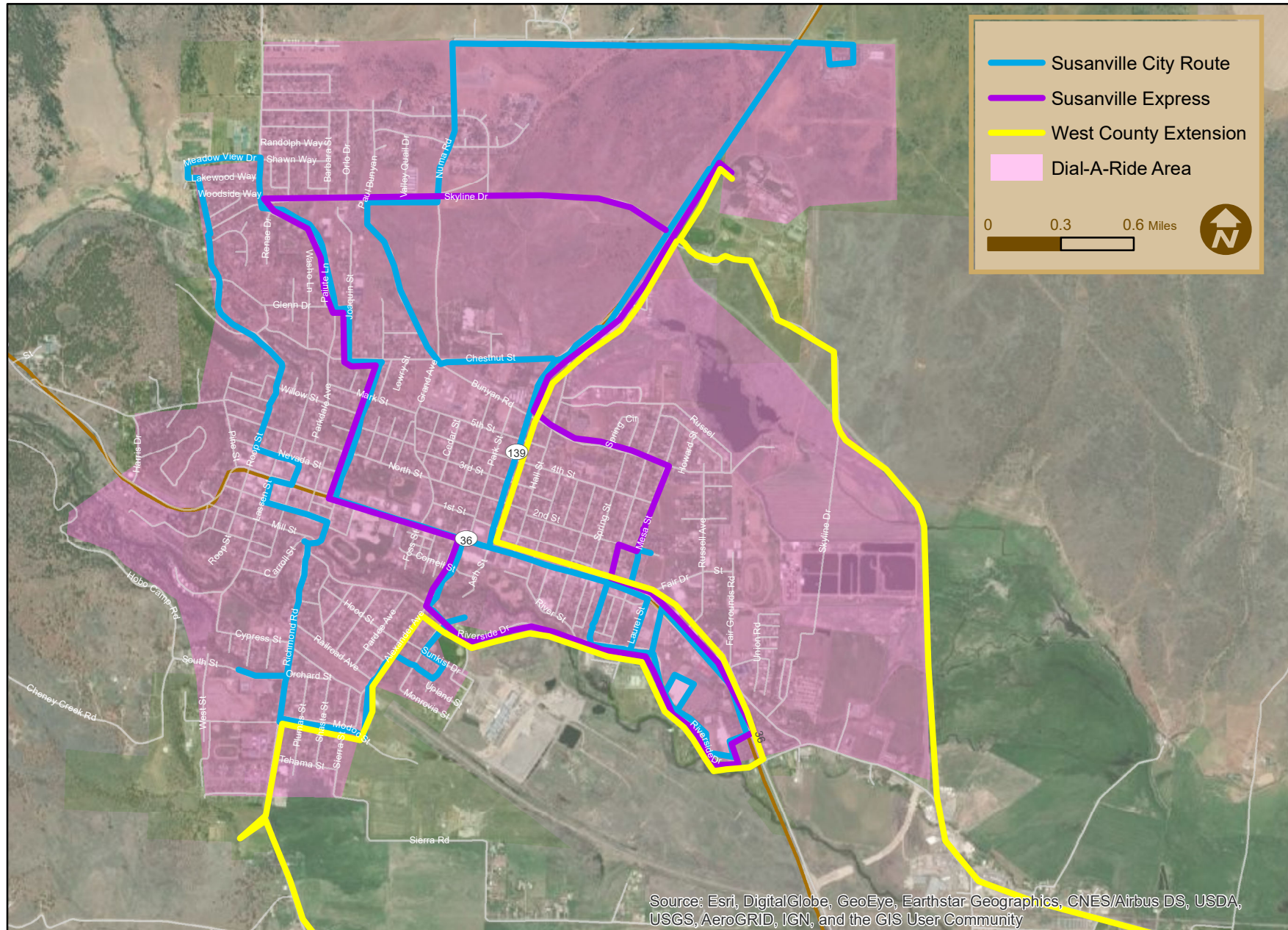


Figure 3
Susanville Route Map



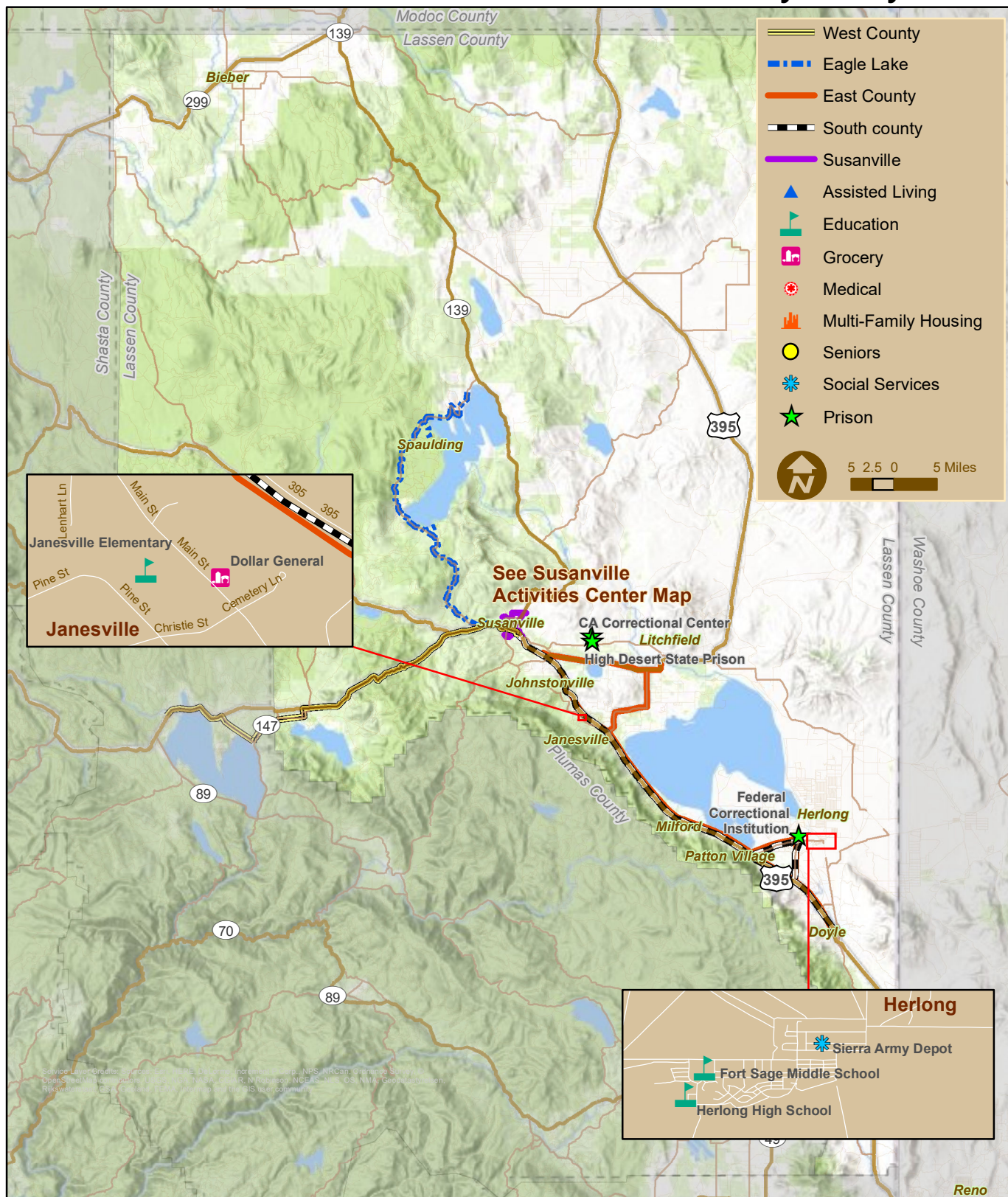


Figure 5
Susanville Activity Centers

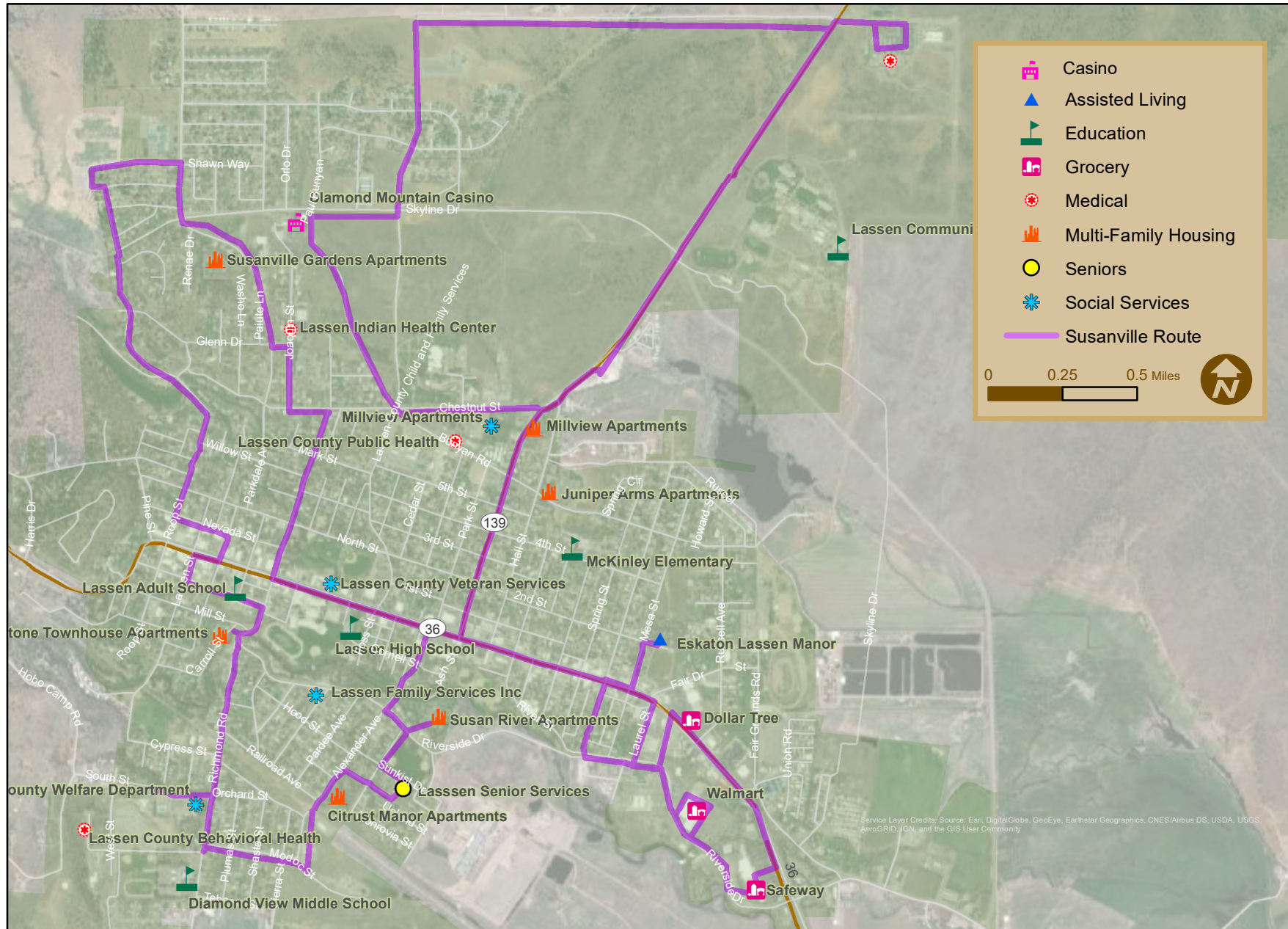


Figure 6
Lassen County Existing and Proposed Bike Facilities



Figure 7

Susanville Existing and Proposed Bicycle Facilities



Proposed Sites for Infrastructure Improvements

- | | |
|---------------------------|-------------------------|
| ① Hospital | ⑨ Lassen High School |
| ② Lassen College | ⑩ Memorial Park |
| ③ County Fairgrounds | ⑪ Susanville Ranch Park |
| ④ Shopping Center | ⑫ Susanville Ranch Park |
| ⑤ Shopping Center | ⑬ Meadowview School |
| ⑥ Riverside Park | ⑭ Susanville Ranch Park |
| ⑦ Diamond View School | ⑮ Skyline Park |
| ⑧ Historic Railroad Depot | ⑯ Bizz Johnson Trail |
| | ⑰ Susan River Trail |

**Existing and
Proposed Bikeways**

- Dirt Path
- Proposed Class III
- - - Proposed Class II
- Existing Class III, Proposed Class II
- - - Proposed Class I
- Existing Class I Bike Path